In 1962, after reading *The Guns of August*, Kennedy told his brother, 'They [Europe's political leaders] somehow seemed to tumble into war … through stupidity, individual idiosyncrasies, misunderstandings, and personal complexes of inferiority and grandeur … He did not want anyone to be able to write, at a later date, a book on the Missiles of October.'[70] Ironically, one of the first accounts of the crisis was entitled *The Missiles of October*, written by Elie Abel, an experienced foreign affairs journalist. Abel was assiduously briefed by the President's friends and officials, and, unsurprisingly, showed Kennedy to be anything other than stupid, idiosyncratic, misunderstanding, or driven by complexes of inferiority or grandeur.[71]

The President was keen for his officials to share Tuchman's insights and asked they read *The Guns of August* – which remained on the *New York Times'* best seller list for forty-two consecutive weeks.[72] Robert Kennedy regularly organised seminars at his home for senior colleagues and arranged for them to discuss the book. Kennedy also gave a copy to Harold Macmillan, whose official biographer records that both Prime Minister and President were 'profoundly affected' by the book.[73] For Macmillan, the Great War was not just history but bitter personal memory. Wounded at the Battle of the Somme, he lost many friends and contemporaries in the war. Macmillan's own reading habits were voracious. In September, he finished Fowler's three volume *Life of Peel* and re-read Disraeli's *Life;* during October 1962, he worked his way through two volumes of a biography of Asquith and Lloyd George's *War Memoirs.*[74] The young Captain Macmillan had taken a copy of Aeschylus's play, *Prometheus* (in Greek), with him into the Battle of the Somme, which he read as he lapsed in and out of consciousness, lying wounded in a shell-hole (his official biographer tells us).[75]

Among the lessons Macmillan took from the events of 1914 was a belief in diplomacy and summitry. He felt that if the British Foreign Secretary, Sir Edward Grey, had gone to a summit in July 1914 instead of going fishing, war could have been avoided.[76] Mobilisation, on the other hand, 'sometimes caused war,' he told the Supreme Allied Commander Europe,